Illustration by TANMOY CHAKRABORY



ies in front of strangers (24:30–31). These parts are called 'satr' or 'awrah', which is the whole body except the face and hands for women, and the area from the knees to the navel for men. Some women choose to cover their faces and hands too, but it is not scripturally mandated.

A woman may observe hijab by wearing a cloak (jilbab) and donning a khimar over her head. Hijab is relaxed in certain situations, like when seeing a doctor, or while appearing in front of a ruler or judge to give witness or file a complaint. Even within a house, members are expected to respect each others' privacy and modesty. Residents of a home, except young children, should not enter anyone else's private room without permission (24:58–59).

Niqab, the full body veil, crept in during later centuries. Full veiling became pervasive only under the long Ottoman rule over large parts of Muslim lands, even then originally as something observed by the aristocracy. Working women could not afford to observe the impractical niqab, but an inevitable downward percolation started as the other classes tried to emulate the elite—encouraged by the more orthodox Salafi clergy. As part of the larger ummah tied to a cultural-religious commons centred around the holy lands, and influenced by figures like the 18th century theologian Shah Waliullah and Salafi schools like Ahl-e-Hadith established in the mid-19th century, the Indian subcontinent was not immune to these transactions of ideas and practices. The full body veil, as mandated attire, has been strongly refuted by many scholars, including one of the great Hadith scholars, Nasir al-Din Al-Albani, in his book *The Hijab of the Muslim Woman*. In general, women in most Muslim societies observe hijab with ordinary clothes; the niqab is uncommon today. The stricter hijab saw a resurgence after the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan and the Islamic Revolution in Iran, both in 1979, and in Egypt at about the same time. Some orthodox Muslims and Salafis still insist on it, though their patron, Saudi Arabia, has officially relaxed it. In recent years, fashion-conscious Muslim women have taken to different types of head coverings, like turbans. Fashion houses, too, have introduced stylish veils for the western and Gulf markets. In general, many women who observe hijab find it practical and liberating, helping them avoid harassment on the streets and in workplaces. ■

In pre-Islamic Arabia, the veil was used to differentiate "free women" from slaves. In the Quranic context, the hijab encourages modesty—physical and spiritual



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POLITICS OF INFLUENCE

The Karnataka school's sudden decision to ban girls wearing hijab from entering its premises reeks of a conspiracy directed at Muslims. In the name of gender empowerment, they are out to build a narrative in which the entire fault lies with the Muslim community, all other communities are fine. They want to demonstrate that schools should have discipline, they should have a uniform.

I do think that schools should have a uniform, and that every student, whatever his or her religion, should adhere to it. But what was the school management doing till now with students who were turning up wearing their religious identity? How